The unrelenting violence unfolded with such extraordinary speed that the Russians declared martial law and sent in T-34 tanks, the same machines that had ploughed through Berlin in 1945. ‘The Russians were ready,’ Rothwell continued. ‘Their machine guns opened up. The men were hit – and the Berlin workers retaliated with a shower of stones on the Red troops.’6 The crisis was so grave that Russian tanks began crawling down Leipziger Straße to Potsdamer Platz, approaching the border with West Berlin. ‘When the first shots came, I sought cover,’ remembered teenager Peter Bruhn, who found himself in the thick of the action. ‘Shortly afterwards, I got to Potsdamer Platz. There, I saw people running in wild panic to get over to the Western sector. Constantly, they had to throw themselves to the ground to seek cover. Some did not get up again.’ From his place in the surging crowd, British reporter, Reginald Peck, ‘watched the steel-helmeted Red Army men train the machineguns of their tanks onto the workers. Then volleys cracked into the air.’ Despite the indomitable spirit of the demonstrators, as daylight faded, so did the Berlin ‘uprising’. That evening, full of bravado, the Russian military commander, Andrei Grechko, sent a radiogram to Moscow: ‘The following number of active provocateurs were caught and executed: one in Berlin, two in Magdeburg, two in Gorlitz, one in Jena. The population was told of the execution of the sentences.’

After anxiously awaiting the outcome of the demonstrations, Ulbricht, along with the Honecker’s and other Politburo members, were chauffeured from Karlshorst back to their homes in Pankow.

That evening, as authorities cleaned up the plaza outside the House of Ministries, West German Commentator, Karl Willy Behr, took to the airwaves of Radio Hamburg (from a studio in the British sector of Berlin) to denounce the state of emergency imposed by the Soviets, which he called ‘a state of war against the population of East Berlin’. It was significant, he said, that the SED government could be protected in no other way but by Soviet bayonets.7

On 24 June, in the presence of about 500,000 Berliners, Chancellor Adenauer pledged the entire nation’s ‘sincere will and desire’ to continue its efforts to bring about German reunification in peace and freedom. Speaking